is well known that women were among the great Upaniṣadic philosophers. Men and women performed sacrifices together. There is not doubt in the minds of scholars and historians about the extreme liberality of attitudes toward all, including even fallen women and women captured in war. To die in defense of women was regarded as the surest way to heaven. Megasthenes, the great Greek historian, who was in India in about 300 B.C., has left a life-like picture of the Indian people. The Greek ambassador observed with admiration "the absence of slavery in India."[3] This is perhaps an exaggeration, because there was slavery of a kind in India during that period, although it was of an altogether different kind from that prevalent in other parts of the world during the same period.

There is positive evidence of equality among the different races that came to India from the outside in early times. The characteristic of the early Indians to absorb different social elements into a unity has been so predominant as to become one of the chief points of Indian culture. That there were marital relationships between these outsiders and Indians is also well known.

The Indian theory of *varṇa,* or classification of society into four classes, was in perfect conformity with then contemporary ideas of freedom and the status of the individual and social justice, and was and remains democratic with regard to the individual's status and his relation to society. It is supposed to be of divine origin, but this is not to be taken literally. It has purely ideological and functional bases and is universal inasmuch as society must have classes of individuals according to their qualifications, interests, and abilities to engage themselves toward the progress of society and toward their own fulfillment, religious or secular. This does not mean that the classification was static or immobile or that an individual, if he was endowed with ability and knowledge, could not attain to whatever classification he aspired.

In India the learned were recognized as the highest class, because only the wise can lead or lay down and perpetuate the faith for the people. They were called *brāhmaṇas,* who are supposed to give us the ideals and faith to live by. The *kṣatriyas* were second—they were the political and military leaders, who were supposed to defend the policies and ends of the social order. Third was the class of the wealth producers and distributors, called *vaiśyas.* The last class was that of the manual workers, craftsmen, and artisans, the *śūdras.* This classification was not based on heredity; birth had nothing to do with it. In their ideological functions there is to be found no fifth class, according to the